Mountain View Historical Association Newsletter

P.O. Box 252
Mountain View, CA 94042

Hilton U. Brown, III - Editor



Southern Pacific Depot — Mountain View, California, built in 1888

Fire Fighting in The Santa Clara Valley
The May Meeting

Leonard W. Williams, CPA, of neighboring Sunnyvale, will present our program for May. He has the unusual hobby of collecting fire engines – real ones, not little toys, and he will be presenting a slide show of the fire engines that he owns.

In addition to being a practicing CPA in Sunnyvale, he also belongs to *Fire Associates of Santa Clara Valley,* a volunteer group that provides canteen services for all Santa Clara County fire departments at fires of extended duration. In that capacity he has served the Mountain View Fire department at many fires over the years, including two Mountain View Academy fires in the early 1970's, and the Minton Lumber Yard fire just a few years ago.

He is the Secretary of the *International Fire Buff Associates;* the Treasurer of the *Society for the Preservation and Appreciation of Antique Motor Fire Apparatus in America;* and a contributing editor for *Fire Apparatus Journal.*

Professionally he is a past president of the Peninsula Chapter of the California CPA Society, a columnist for the Society's magazine, and a member of the its statewide Tax Committee. He is frequently quoted in the *San Jose Mercury News* Saturday real estate section.

California's First Legislature
The February Meeting

Mary Jo Ignoffo was our speaker at the February 6, 2000 meeting. She is the author of the recently published *Gold Rush Politics: California's First Legislature,* author of *Sunnyvale: From the City of Destiny to the Heart of Silicon Valley,* and a former editor of *The Californian*. She is currently working on the *History of Mountain View*, which is due for publication in 2001.

Ms. Ignoffo presented anecdotes from the first California Legislative Assembly, which met in San Jose in 1849. She particularly mentioned persons and families prominent in Santa Clara County and Mountain View, including such names as Whisman, Stierlin, Brawley and Crosby.

Ms. Ignoffo's current project, the *History of Mountain View,* is sponsored by the Mountain View Historical Association. The meeting was a fine opportunity to meet "our" author and gain some insight into what "our history" will be like.

Executive Committee Meeting

The Executive Committee of the Mountain View Historical Association met March 2, 2000.

The Treasurer was directed to move the Association's bank account from Bank of America to Bank of Los Altos. The move is prompted by a substantially higher interest rate and a substantially larger set of services for small Not-for-Profits.

The Membership report is presented elsewhere in this Newsletter. We have eight new Regular Members and one new Life Member. Help in recruiting new members will be appreciated.

We are investigating the costs of publishing the *History of Mountain View* so that we may seek out whatever support and assistance will be required. In this connection, the Association will join the California Historical Center.

We will again participate in supporting the Small Brewers Festival.

We will continue the calling of the membership to alert them to upcoming meetings. In addition, we will offer to arrange transportation for members who may have difficulty in getting to the meetings.

Liz and Mario Ambra have agreed to serve as co-chairs of the Program Committee.

The next meetings of the Association will be Sunday, May 7, 2000; the Annual Barbecue, Sunday, August 6, 2000; the Annual Meeting and Election of Officers, Sunday November 5, 2000; and Sunday, February 4, 2001.

Need Transportation?

Need transportation to the Sunday, May 7, meeting of the Mountain View Historical Association?
Give Wally Ericksen a call at (650) 948-2644. Wally will try to help in finding a driver from your area who can offer you a ride.

Elmer Stricklett by Carol Fischer

"Take me out to the ballgame, take me out to the crowd, buy me some ... "

Ah, spring is in the air and to many sports fans that means baseball. This year is particularly exciting for Bay Area baseball fans with the opening of PacBell Park, the new Giants stadium in San Francisco. For local enthusiasts, a little known baseball trivia fact revolves around Mountain View resident Elmer Stricklett who is credited with being the father of the spitball. A spitball, now illegal, is a pitch in which saliva is surreptitiously applied to one part of the ball, so as to make it break or swerve unpredictably.

Elmer Stricklett was born in Glasco Kansas on August 29, 1876. He made his major league pitching debut for the Chicago White Sox in 1904 but was traded to the Brooklyn Dodgers the following year. He played with that team until 1907. Elmer five feet six inches, weighed 140 pounds and pitched and batted right handed. His career average ERA (earned run average) was 2.84. Elmer introduced the overhand spitball during a Dodgers/Giants game on May 29, 1905. He taught the pitch to "Big Ed" Walsh of the Chicago White Sox who went on to become one of the best spitballers in all of baseball.

How is Elmer Stricklett related to Mountain View? He married a local girl, Mabel Gates. Mabel's parents, Mary Julia Burk and Benjamin Gates, came to Mountain View in 1885 when Mabel was eight years old. The family settled into a home on Calderon Avenue. Mrs. Gates was a writer of local history. She wrote one of the first histories of the area in 1895 as well as articles for the Mountain View Register Leader on local Indians, the various landings on the bay, and about such prominent families as the Castros and the Estradas. Benjamin Gates was believed to have been one of the first orchardists in the area. Mabel Stricklett's uncle, Dr. Frederick Burk (or Burke) was the president of the State Normal School in San Francisco (now San Francisco State University) for many years.

In 1912, Elmer Stricklett tried to make a pitching comeback but never made it back to the big leagues.

He and Mabel retired to Santa Cruz where he died in 1964 and she in 1968.

Visitors to the Mountain View History Center can see a picture of Elmer Stricklett in his 1906 Brooklyn Dodgers uniform. There are also photographs of Mabel Gates Stricklett and her parents, Mary Julia and Benjamin Gates in the collection. Perhaps one can even catch a whiff of "... peanuts and Cracker Jacks ... "

New to the Mountain View History Center by Barbara Kinchen

From Mrs. Mary Tutman: 1870 deed to property on El Camino near Bay Street sold to George Sonnenberg by Crisanto Castro, Angela Castro, Andres Calderon and wife, Merced Castro Calderon. The writing is legible as are the signatures.

From Charles Welch: Framed photo, 2 ft. x 3 ft., of Mountain View High School on Castro in the late 1980s and a poster with signatures of attendees at one of the high school reunions held at the Elks Club.

From Julie Campbell: A box of Stierlin Family items – pictures, documents, letters, etc. from the estate of Mrs. Lisetta Jansen Mieth Challen, the great granddaughter of Conrad C. Stierlin, for whom Stierlin Road was named.

From Member Margaret Vidovich: Class pictures from her days in the elementary schools in Mountain View. Names of pupils are carefully written on the backs.

From Member Betty McLaren: A syllabus by Betty McLaren, "The Space To Rage, About What They Did To Our Daughters."

From Member Betty Engberg: Bottle with label from Knight's Pharmacy, 292 Castro Street, "Knight Fills Prescriptions Right."

Old Newspaper Items Compiled By Barbara Kinchen

100 Years Ago (1900): A petition signed by 120 men and 180 women of Fremont Township, requested county supervisors not to grant any more licenses for saloons within the township.

Articles of Incorporation were filed for the Bank of Mountain View, the first bank in town, with capital stock of $25,000.

Those seeking certification for teaching in high schools spent eight days taking tests to qualify. Here are two questions from the examination. Give a full synopsis of the verb *break* and of the verb phrase *to break* in the indicative mood. A merchant mixes 40 pounds of tea at 45¢ a pound with 50 pounds at 27¢ a pound and sells the mixture at 42¢ per pound. What percent profit did he make?

75 Years Ago (1925): The flag pole in the new city park on Castro Street was given by the American Legion Auxiliary.

The Saddle Hawk, starring Hoot Gibson, was at the Glen Theater.

Three canneries were in operation locally; Clark Cannery on Stierlin Road, California Supply (Pickle Works) and Santa Clara Conserve Company at Bailey Avenue and the railroad tracks.

Basil L. Hayes (Bay Hays) was appointed city clerk to fill the vacancy created by the resignation of Charles N. Lake.

Swimmers and divers from Mountain View High School entertained the many people who attended the opening of Kingsport Plunge at South Shore Port, on the bay at the end of Whisman Road.

50 Years Ago (1950): The Berry Farm, 1101 El Camino Real, had cauliflower for 5¢, a dozen local eggs for 29¢, MJB coffee at 75¢ a pound, and margarine sold for 31¢ colored but 21¢ a pound if uncolored.

Permits were issued for 394 homes in William Blackfield's Rex Manor subdivision, priced at $6975 for two bedrooms and $7575 for three. Other new homes were being constructed by Gamel Company off the east side of Calderon Avenue and Sunnyview Lane off Sleeper Avenue. Here veterans could buy with $400 down, $70 a month - $10,675 total.

Reynolds Camp bought the real estate business from Roger Smith, who had purchased it from William P. Wright in 1948.

Police Officer Vernon Laveroni was recognized for his work with the Mountain View Boys Club, sponsored by the police department.

A Lutheran Church was organized and with Rev. Robert W. Visser in charge, services were being held in the Adobe Building.

Ground was broken for the $1,000,000 Ferry-Morse Seed Company plant on Evelyn Avenue.

Grand Openings: Tak's Stationers at 823 El Camino, Goddard Furniture 803 El Camino, Randall Variety Store at Church and Calderon and Whitey and Bill's Richfield Station on the corner of Castro and California Street.

Rain postponed the second annual May Day Fete sponsored by the Woman's Club. A week later over 200 children participated in folk dancing, singing and a Maypole dance in City Hall Park.

Martin Spangler and Robert Rowe, incumbents, were re-elected to council positions. A rival candidate alleged they had violated a handbill ordinance by handing out cards all over town and stuffing handbills in letter boxes.

25 Years Ago (1975): City Manager Richard De Long proposed a $16 million Capital Improvement program to include remodeling of the Escuela Avenue Sunnyview Club into a senior citizen center.

Newhall Land Company, owners since 1960 of former Rengstorff land on Stierlin Road, filed plans for a $15 million industrial park. An auto speedway and high density residential use had been previously suggested for the 140 acres. Newhall offered the heavily-damaged Rengstorff house free of charge to anyone who would remove it.

Fire destroyed a counselor's office, classroom and the band practice room containing uniforms and instruments at the high school on Castro Street. Four students were soon arrested and charged with arson, burglary and malicious mischief.

Elected three years previously as first woman on the city council, Judith Moss was chosen mayor - another first for a woman. Last year it took 46 ballots to select the mayor, this year it was done on the first ballot.

Street Talk From Barbara Kinchen

The **February Street Talk Puzzler** was: *Where is Eldora Drive, and for whom was it named?* Well, it's off Calderon between Church and Dana.

Eldora Freeman married Jack McCarty, whose parents had bought land on Calderon Avenue in 1885. Jack was a surveyor and Eldora was a teacher. Subdivision of their land began in 1940 and two streets carry on their names: Eldora Drive and McCarty Avenue.

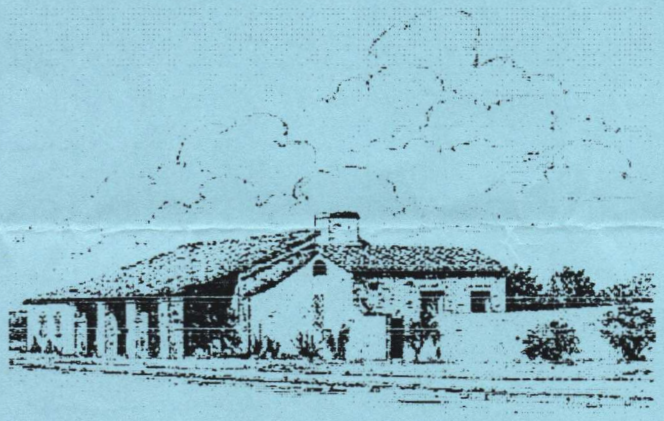
And this leads to the **May Street Talk Puzzler** — *For whom was Calderon Avenue named?*

Mountain View City Council Actions of Special Interest

Adobe Restoration

On January 11, 2000 the Mountain View City Council approved the plans and specifications for the Adobe Building Restoration and authorized staff to advertise for bids. The restoration will include structural and seismic improvements to bring the building into code compliance, concealed heating, ventilation, power and communications, renovated kitchen, and retrofitting of the fireplace. A perimeter wall, designed to appear as the original adobe wall will be built.

The architectural consultant has prepared documentation to upgrade the Adobe Building's historic designation and nominate it to the National Register of Historic Places.



If all goes according to plan, the City will award the construction contract in April, work will commence in May, and should be completed in January, 2001.

Shockley Semiconductor Commemorative Marker

On April 11, 2000 the Mountain View City Council approved the placement of a commemorative marker recognizing the historical significance of the Shockley Semiconductor Laboratory located at 391 South San Antonio Road. The building, know as *the barn* to those who worked there is the point of origin for the commercial transistor, and therefore a cornerstone of modern computer technology.

Pioneer Park Irrigation and Grounds Improvements.

Pioneer Memorial Park, located off Church Street between Franklin and Castro is an oasis in the midst of downtown Mountain View. It was once the primary cemetery for Mountain View, and the remains of many of the city's pioneering residents are still buried there. Irrigation and Grounds Improvements are required, and the Council approved the work on April 11, 2000. The Council required assurances that the work not disturb the remains. The council also asked that additional benches be included in the park.

Hospitality!

Before and after the meeting there will be ample opportunity to examine the historic documents brought over from the Mountain View History Center, to chat with the other attendees, and afterwards sample the refreshments!

Mountain View History Center

The *Mountain View History Center*, successor to the Mountain View *Pioneer Room*, is a wonderful resource for the City of Mountain View. A substantial part of the collection is that of the Mountain View Historical Association. Several Association members regularly volunteer here.

The following has been abstracted from the April 2000, vol.45 no.4, of the Newsletter of the *Santa Clara County Historical and Genealogical Society*, by Peggy Rossi.

The Mountain View Historical Association in conjunction with the Mountain View Public Library, maintains a local history reading room and local exhibits. The History Center is located at the Mountain View Public Library, 585 Franklin St. The center is open on Tuesday, Thursday and Saturday from 1 PM to 5 PM..

Whether you have family from Mountain View or not, this center is worth a visit, not only to have a chance to see the beautiful new Mountain View library but to look at the historical exhibits and photographs. For those whose families hail from Mountain View, there is a wealth of information to be found here.

Among the resources here are: microfilm of Mountain View newspapers (such as the Mountain View Register and the Leader) dating from 1903 into the 1960s, (found in the main library collection); Assessment Rolls from 1903-1930s; Indexes to Voter Precinct Registers, early registers of business licenses (pre-1930), and city directories.

A particular treasure is the Winter's Collection. Mildred Winter, a retired history professor from San Jose State University, had gathered volumes of information in preparation for the publication of a book on the history of Mountain View. Unfortunately, she passed away before the book could be published. However all her notes are available in binders and include material from 1849 to 1929, such as clippings, probate and deed extracts.

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There are extensive versicle files with a large collection of photographs and clippings. The photographs are all being scanned at this time so they will be available to researchers via computer. This process is allowing the Association the opportunity to make sure each photograph is identified and dated when that information is available.

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This is an excellent collection, in an attractive and comfortable setting and well worth a visit, especially if your family lived in Mountain View.

